

Pedagogical terms and methods

No need to memorize these terms, but feel free to use them as a “cheat sheet” to help you if you don’t know the meaning of certain pedagogical terms.

Term	Definition
Active learning	A teaching and learning approach that "engages students in the process of learning through activities and/or discussion in class, as opposed to passively listening to an expert. It emphasizes higher-order thinking and often involves group work.
Asynchronous Instruction	The idea that students learn similar material at different times and locations. The term is often associated with online learning where students complete readings, assignments, or activities at their own pace and at their own chosen time. This approach is particularly useful when students are spread across different time zones or may have limited access to technology.
Backward Design	Beginning with the goal in mind and then designing assessments, activities, and finally content.
Blended or Hybrid Course	Classes in which some percentage of seat time has been reduced and replaced with online content and activities. These courses continue to meet in-person for some percentage of the class time but content, activities, assessments, and other ways for students to engage with content are delivered online. It is important to note that these courses are intentionally designed to utilize both in-person and online class time to achieve effective student learning.

Constructivism	A theory contending that when learners acquire new knowledge, it is through a dynamic process in which the learner recreates existing mental models, situating this new information in terms of what they already know. Social constructivists additionally recognize the role of social interaction (co-construction) and communication as key forces in learning. Students learn through experiential means, active exploration, student interaction, and reflection. Courses designed around this principle emphasize connections among course concepts and themes and support students in forming relationships between this new knowledge and what they already know.
Experiential Learning	A process by which students develop knowledge and skills from direct experience, usually outside a traditional academic setting. Examples include: internships, study abroad, community-based learning, service learning, and research opportunities. The concept was introduced by David Kolb in 1984 and combines both a cognitive and behavioral approach to learning.
Flipped Classroom	A teaching approach where students are first exposed to content before coming to a class session and then spend class time engaging more deeply with the ideas and concepts. This model encourages the use of active learning during in-person class sessions to allow students to explore concepts, solve problems, and discuss ideas with each other and the instructor.
Formative Assessment	The process of providing feedback to students during the learning process. These are often low stakes activities that allow the instructor to check student work and provide feedback.

	An instructor writing comments and suggestions on a draft version of a paper is an example.
Learning Management System (LMS)	A platform that enables instructors to organize and distribute course materials in a digital format. While features may vary, this typical system allows instructors to communicate with students, share readings, create and collect assignments, assess student work and post grades. This type of system may be used to compliment a face-to-face course or for an entirely online course. Popular platforms include Canvas, Blackboard, and Moodle.
Learning Objective/Learning Goal/Learning Outcome	Statements that articulate the knowledge and skills you want students to acquire by the end of the course or after completing a particular unit or assignment. These help instructors to shape course content and assessments as well as increase transparency for students by clearly communicating expectations.
Pedagogy	The method, practice and study of effective teaching. In order to be effective, instructors must have both subject-based knowledge and pedagogic knowledge and skills
Scaffolding	A process by which instructors build on a student's previous experience or knowledge by adding in specific timely support structures in the form of activities or assignments for students to master new knowledge or skills and achieve learning goals
Summative Assessment	The process of measuring a student's learning at the conclusion of a course (or a portion of the course). Are typically associated with grades and can take the form of quizzes, exams or papers.

Synchronous instruction	The idea that students learn material at the same time. Examples of this might include lectures, discussions or collaborative activities. When applied to remote learning, students must be online at the same time. This approach can be disadvantageous if students are spread across different time zones or have limited access to technology.
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